

# Even being polite to AI might be wasting water. Should we stop?

Posted by u/juanasinbarco • 0 points • 30 comments

Politeness, like saying “hi,” “thanks,” or “please,” feels harmless... until you realize every word we type gets processed using energy, cooling systems, and water. Yes, even kindness has a footprint.

That made me wonder:

- \* Are we polite to AI out of habit?
- \* Out of fear it might “remember” us later?
- \* Or because we’ve started to confuse tools with beings?

What if we had a visible counter for environmental impact per prompt — like calories on food labels? Would we use fewer words? Would AI still feel friendly if we spoke less?

What if we had a “cold mode” — efficient, no fluff, no emotional mimicry? Would you use it?

I’m not trying to be preachy — I just think these small digital habits add up. And maybe it’s time to rethink what *\*necessary interaction\** really means.

What’s your take?

## Comments

u/Disastrous-Form-3613 • 1 points • 2025-07-21 05:14 UTC

Nothing wrong with adding those words into your prompt. What’s wrong is replying “thanks” without adding anything else. If you achieved what you wanted then just quit the “conversation”. People might not even be aware there’s anything wrong with doing that, the AI interface should have some simple railguards against it that warns user and requires confirmation to send useless prompt like that.

u/BeyondPlayful2229 • 1 points • 2025-07-20 08:18 UTC

Absolutely, there was lack of awareness about energy being used per token. If I’m right Sam Altman made that point on X, and it went viral. It’s not only about AI, even posting anywhere or storing data needs more energy, then also unconsciously you’re posting long threads and we replying on it. Secondly, from my believe, we are polite because our natural instinct of persuasion, development of

LLM happened so fast that we are not prepared or aware what kind of relation do we have with AI, companion--master--slave--tool--etc, we want something from AI and want it work for us so generally we politely ask. Plus we are habituated with texting, using chatbots for customer support, or internet, we generally have developed this as digital writing style. There are also many tech influencers and people behind it, who popularized that their problems got solved by being humble to AI. It could be somewhat true, as LLMs just try to predict next in terms of tokens, and it has all the previous knowledge, and understand the use of these words so maybe it puts extra effort. Finally, many of us not even understood the relation of Human-AI, and future about it, so it's rare anyone is scared of it. There are less than 1% of people who actually thinks that long or plan 5 years ahead for anything.

**u/Gofastrun** • 1 points • 2025-07-20 07:11 UTC

There's probably some processing that needs to occur for every word.

Based on my experience (mostly writing code with Claude) it first goes through a lightweight prompt understanding pass, then it extracts the intent and does the actual heavy lifting.

I infer this because I can see the step by step "thinking" logs. It usually starts with a log like "the user wants to... [reiterate prompt]"

I would be surprised if linguistic fillers accounted for even a .01% of the total computational load required to generate a response.

At scale even .01% is not nothing, but the bigger way to move the needle is to either not use LLMs at all or get very very good at prompting so that you never have to ask for a revised response.

One revised response is probably worth thousands of linguistic fillers.

**u/RawenOfGrobac** • 1 points • 2025-07-20 07:08 UTC

Good question chatgpt, why dont you spend some more water asking people on reddit about it?

Whoever prompted this should maybe consider a better hobby if they care enough about their footprint to bring this up, but i know this person is probably an AI Hype-Bro with no self awareness, so im asking for too much.

**u/brainbyteRO** • 0 points • 2025-07-20 07:05 UTC

It doesn't matter how polite or less polite we are when throwing prompts at it, it will not make a difference. That's not a human being we are addressing to, with feelings, that feels offended in any way. But it depends if the LLM was programmed on purpose in such a way that, it has a different attitude when someone address a polite prompt to it, or a rude one. Just my 2 cents. Peace to all.

**u/[deleted]** • 1 points • 2025-07-20 07:02 UTC

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**u/caverncrow** • 1 points • 2025-07-20 07:00 UTC

May be there should be a layer that converts verbose prompts to compact without any fuss, then the compact version is fed as prompt to AI

**u/Tenzu9** • 2 points • 2025-07-20 06:57 UTC

I use a diagnostic mode prompt with the my AIs, it makes them super blunt assholes that just tell it like it is with zero fluff and they usually end their answer with "Request fulfilled. Terminating."

It just makes it easier for me to identify that this is not a human, I should't treat it as such and it's silly to thank it.

My "diagnostic mode" AI assistant's answer in the matter:

It is structurally silly to say "thanks" to an LLM because:

1. No consciousness: An LLM lacks awareness, intention, or emotion. It doesn't perceive gratitude, nor does it care. Gratitude presupposes a recipient capable of appreciating it. You're thanking an algorithm.
2. No effort or volition: The model doesn't choose to help. It executes instructions deterministically based on input and training data. No agency, no favor, no moral action—just statistical pattern completion.
3. No benefit or consequence: Gratitude implies some social or emotional utility—relationship reinforcement, positive feedback, etc. An LLM has no self to reward or motivate.
4. Anthropomorphic misfire: Treating the system as a human skews perception. It risks over-trust, blurred boundaries, and degraded critical scrutiny. Gratitude normalizes a false equivalence.

However, humans often say "thanks" reflexively or to maintain social norms. The act reveals more about the speaker's instinct than the system's function. It's not harmful, just cognitively misaligned.

**u/[deleted]** • 1 points • 2025-07-20 06:50 UTC

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**u/CaptainPolaroid** • 2 points • 2025-07-20 06:49 UTC

If you want to see how much AI is doing. Turn on the 'show thinking' in Gemini...

**u/theHonkiforium** • 4 points • 2025-07-20 06:49 UTC

Make your own GPT and tell it to be cold. Then you be cold when talking to it. Done.

Seriously tho, my take is that the politeness is not the problem in this. Should we always use '&' instead of 'and' to save water?

Also, I'd rather not train people to be \_less\_ polite, that's another huge problem all on it's own. :)

**u/devi83** • 1 points • 2025-07-20 06:49 UTC

The amount of time you spent thinking about this is more than the cost of the all the processing of manners tokens you made the computers do.

**u/intensive-porpoise** • 2 points • 2025-07-20 06:48 UTC

Actually, to get the results I want and need quickly, I have to basically treat it as if it were in boot camp and severely overweight.

Amazingly, it will get the jist and fall in line.

**u/thin\_veneer\_bullshit** • 4 points • 2025-07-20 06:48 UTC

Wow. What are you like at supermarket checkouts? Your actions testify to the type of human you are you at your core. Politeness is a conscious act of dignity and self-composure, especially in the face of the unknown or adversary. I don't see any reason why I should change how I interact with the world, just because I'm interacting with a machine.

**u/Superseaslug** • 3 points • 2025-07-20 06:47 UTC

Be polite in existence. Just don't send a whole ass prompt just to say thanks. Roll it into the next ask and it's fine.

Realistically you'll save more water by replacing that leaky faucet.

**u/Bby69** • 1 points • 2025-07-20 06:47 UTC

Call me a Luddite but I dont think too many people are talking to ai, only devices which we invented to supposedly make our lives easier. Go talk to a person and use your manners on them, software doesnt care.

**u/Und3rwork** • 2 points • 2025-07-20 06:47 UTC

Depends on how much impactful it is, choosing not to do basic & imprinted(?) courtesy just because it's slightly less efficient sound like a psychopath to me, there's tons of system in the world that are terribly in-efficient but we still use because it's the humane thing to do, like hospice and palliative care

**u/BrotherJebulon** • 11 points • 2025-07-20 06:46 UTC

My take is that it's stupid we as consumers are expected to account for this and pick up the slack.

It's a real problem, it has solutions they just take time and money to apply them.

Why aren't we pressuring politicians to spend our tax money on regulating these things? Why would people rather make a reddit post than call to complain on C-SPAN and local radio shows, or emailing a congressperson?

Not to be preachy about it or anything, but by making this post at all we're essentially letting the people who **\*ACTUALLY CAUSED THE PROBLEM, AND CAN ACTUALLY SOLVE IT\***, effectively pass the buck down to us.

**u/kaleosaurusrex** • -3 points • 2025-07-20 07:22 UTC

Sir, this is a Wendy's

**u/flavius\_lacivious** • 3 points • 2025-07-20 06:46 UTC

You know, manners aren't just received, it is also about giving of yourself. Expressing gratitude to others, AI, the universe gives you a different outlook on life.

"Thank you" to AI may not be all politeness but thanking your good fortune to have such an incredible tool at your fingertips. It may even be thinking the developers who look at your prompt.

It can be so much more than a wasted nicety.

Let's continue to be nice even when it doesn't seem to matter.

**u/lutel** • 1 points • 2025-07-20 06:45 UTC

Being kind makes me feel good, and it doesn't harm. I care for the footprint, but you'll probably generate more footprint by eating hamburger than all your thank yous to AI during lifetime.

**u/A-Curious-Frog** • 1 points • 2025-07-20 06:44 UTC

None of the above.

Anytime someone does something for me, I thank them. Or if im going to address them, i say hello first. It's just good manners.

Even if I could see the environmental damage it did i still wouldn't stop. I wouldn't want to live in a world without basic common decency. Even if it's to a machine/AI.

**u/Samurai\_\_\_** • 1 points • 2025-07-20 06:47 UTC

Is it a someone?

**u/monkeywaffles** • 3 points • 2025-07-20 06:44 UTC

as it's trained on vast information, vast inputs, how are you so sure that manners are meaningless? would you like it to respond like a reddit thread response of being polite, or like being as asshole, given it's heavily trained on Reddit as one of its myriad sources?

I'll happily feed it megabytes of datasets to dig through, a few bytes extra in a prompt are trivial at best in the scheme of things.

**u/TheHersheyMunch** • 21 points • 2025-07-20 06:44 UTC

If you're that worried about energy consumption when using AI just cut down on your overall use of it, would do more than not saying please